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Husserl, Givenness, and the Priority of the Self

Ian Leask

Abstract

This article argues that, despite its apparent radicality, Husserl's later, genetic phenomenology ends up confirming and consolidating a very orthodox transcendental egology.

First, the article reconstructs an Husserlian phenomenology of givenness; but then, by considering the ambiguous role of intuition, it also establishes (a) the continued prestige of a 'classical' transcendental subject, and (b) the way in which a denial of ontology allows Husserl's transcendental subject to sublate the provocative challenge of primal *Gegebenheit*.

Overall, the article argues that Husserl is subject to a deep egological faultline, brought about by the self-consciously anti-ontological nature of his project: 'givenness without Being', it suggests, necessitates a prioritized and privileged self.

Keywords: phenomenology; givenness; Husserl

Husserl's later phenomenology seems both to deny and to confirm the regime of the 'traditional' modern subject. On the one hand, and in a move of profound radicality, Husserl's geneticism breaks through to the givenness on which intentionality and constitution depend, the affective bedrock beneath and beyond subjectivity; Husserl thereby undoes the priority of the self, and reveals the ego to be dependent, passive, and, 'in the final analysis', constituted. On the other hand, Husserl seems to draw back from this radicality and reinstate the supposed primacy of 'mainstream' subjectivity; despite its deconstructive power, genetic phenomenology thereby returns to an idealism – an idealism which is confirmed in its certitude by the same geneticism's breakthrough to givenness. In short, we could say that Husserlian givenness ends up confirming egology.

In this article, I want to show how and why this slide – or, perhaps, *Aufhebung* – takes place. In particular, I hope not just to identify an 'egological faultline' in Husserl's geneticism, but also to demonstrate how this faultline is the outcome of a denied ontology characterizing his œuvre

as a whole: in this respect, I suggest, 'givenness without Being' is no different from Husserl's earlier phenomenological efforts in its prioritizing of the self.

Accordingly, I shall consider four main issues: (1) the geneticism which allows for Husserl's radical breakthrough to the passive givenness assumed by any constitution; (2) the ambiguous position of intuition vis-à-vis this givenness; (3) the way in which, because of this ambiguity, the transcendental ego can appropriate givenness; (4) the way in which this appropriation is determined by Husserl's approach to 'the ontological' in general. Overall, this should demonstrate how the initial radicality gives way to – or is sublated by – a very orthodox autarchy.

All of which is not to deny the significance of the phenomenology of givenness. It is more to highlight certain aporiai of self-consciously anti-ontological approaches to this deepest of phenomenological issues.

I Husserl's Genetic Phenomenology and the Givenness of Things Themselves

It is a matter of no little surprise that Husserl, apparently the transcendental egologist *par excellence*, should have pursued the question of selfhood to a point where any self-satisfied subjectivity threatens to turn on itself and come undone. For this would seem to be the startling implication of what is surely Husserl's most rigorous explication of the active, constituting ego – his 'genetic turn'. Indeed, what he identifies here, in his analysis of 'monadic becoming', is something like a rupture within subjectivity, brought about as the subject's own striving gestures towards a fundamental 'immersed passivity' which, it finds, it can never fully grasp yet must always presuppose. A cluster of terms – *Abbau*, operative intentionality, passive genesis, *Rückgang* – is testament to this centripetal tendency in Husserl's later work, a tendency towards that primal and original givenness which his earlier, static analysis had effaced. To appreciate the radical force of Husserl's discovery, we need to chart the genesis of genetic phenomenology itself.

In general terms, we could say that the 'genetic turn' comes about as Husserl devotes greater attention to the question of carnal presence (*Leibhaft*), hyletic materiality, and sensuous receptivity: as a 'transcendental aesthetics'¹ makes matter and 'content' more prominent concerns, so the privileged position of categorical constitution seems to become reconfigured. In the *LI*, sense-data may provide 'primary contents', and categorial intuition may be based on sensuous intuition (*LI* VI, s. 60); but there is no question of meaning arising from perception. Instead, formal meanings are deemed timeless, non-spatial, and 'already there',² and perception 'merely' allows for fulfilment: sensory data can only 'offer themselves' to an animating, meaning-bestowing stratum.³ Sense is,

accordingly, ‘ensouled’ by intentional acts (*LI V*, s. 14), and objectifying interpretation, *objektivierende Deutung*, comes ‘on top of’ pure sense-data – it ‘goes to work’ on sensations. What really counts boils down to *the experiences of thinking and knowing* (*LI I*, s. 1; 249 / *Hua XIX/I*, 6). By the time of *Id. 1* there is a certain redress: perception is more explicitly seen to provide for possible constitution, and Husserl can even talk of ‘wait[ing], in pure surrender, on what is essentially given’ (s. 88).⁴ Nonetheless, the noetic–noematic correlation, still treated as ‘eternal’ and ‘ready-made’, remains privileged over hyletic data (which themselves require noetic animation), meaning is ‘located within’ the noema (sensations are, literally, meaning-less), and materiality is all but ignored (the focus is on ‘how’ rather than ‘what’).⁵ It is only once the findings of *Id. 1* are reformulated in terms of the earlier Göttingen time lectures that the pieces come together, so to speak, and the ego begins to be revealed as constituted within the flux of retention and protention, the noematic as layered and ‘historical’, and the noetic and hyletic as themselves ‘temporal’. Formerly banished,⁶ genesis is now allowed in from the cold.⁷

Accordingly, in *Id. 2*, Husserl begins to address a primal, passive intentionality, an affective aspect to constitution: with his ‘new’ stress on ‘the foundedness [*Fundiertheit*] of the psychic in the material’ (*Id. 2*, s.13; 32/*Hua 29*), on the significance of the ‘sensuous-aesthetic stratum’, indeed, on ‘the psychophysical subject as a whole [*das gesamte psychophysische Subjekt*]’ (*Id. 2*, 18c; 80/75), so Husserl can now indicate those ‘ultimate, primitive, primal objects no longer constituted by any kind of Ego-activity whatsoever [*als letzten primitiven Urgegenständen, die nicht mehr durch irgend welche Ichaktivität Konstituiert*]’ but which form a ‘*pregivenness* [*Vorgegebenheiten*] for all the Ego’s operations’ (s. 54; 226/214).⁸ (‘They are subjective’, Husserl tells us, ‘but they are *not states or acts of the Ego*; rather, they are *what is had by the Ego*’ (ibid.).⁹

However, it is with the seminal labours of the *APAS*, *EJ* and *FTL* that the realm of pre-predicative, passive receptivity is given the fuller and more developed treatment which it would seem to deserve (and which has been incubating over the previous decade or so). We could say that, whereas static phenomenology sought the invariant, eidetic structures which ‘found’ ontic consideration,¹⁰ Husserl now seeks to unveil something of the origin of these structures themselves, something of ‘the storied structure of constitution’ (*APAS*, s. 48, 270/*Hua XVII*, 219). Uncovering (*Enthüllung*) the hidden methods of formation (*Bildungsmethoden*) can reveal, Husserl suggests, ‘a sort of historicity’ (*eine Art Historizität*) (*FTL*, s. 85, 208/*Hua 215*),¹¹ eventually, we might encounter, in the dynamic strata-formation of meaning, ‘the deeper-lying genesis pertaining to ultimate “cores” [*Kernen*] and pointing back to their origin’ (s. 85, 208/216). Thus the aim is ‘[to] ask the “finished” unities about their constitution’ (ibid.), to move ‘backwards’, from idealities, to ‘original consciousness’ (*Original bewußtsein*)

(s. 86, 209/217), to 'the non-predicative evidence called *experience* [or: *encounter* (*Erfahrung*)]' (ibid). In other words: we retrace our steps, from the likes of propositional certainty, fulfilment, and 'correctness', to an 'originally engendering activity' (*Ursprünglich erzeugende Aktivität*), itself based upon 'the givings of things themselves [*Selbstgebungen*]' (s. 86, 210/217). We do not just go back to the things themselves: we go back to the *givenness* of the things themselves.

It seems far from coincidental, in this respect, that Husserl should explicate his new, genetic approach by contrasting it to the 'naïveté' of the Cartesian cogito: the distance he establishes here is not just that between his *Rückgang* and Descartes's 'confusions' (and their post-Cartesian heritage); it is also recognition of the emerging gap between his contemporary concerns with the 'wider concrete nexus' (*Zusammenhang*)¹² and his earlier, static methodology. Thus, when Husserl charges that Descartes is blind to the worldliness of the ego and to that '*sense-moment* [*Sinnesmoment*] pertaining to externality [*Äußerlichkeit*]' (*FTL*, s. 93, 230/238) (a moment which is already contained in the psyche, or *mens*), we can detect a certain self-reproach in operation: the 'new' Husserl will no longer consider *Erfahrung* as merely an 'opening' through which the world 'shines into a room of consciousness' (s. 94, 232/239); encounter is in no sense 'a mere taking of something alien to consciousness into consciousness' (ibid.). Where the Cartesian cogito (and by implication, perhaps, the 'static' transcendental ego) dismissed experience for its lack of apodictic evidence; and where the eternal verity of 'worldless', a priori inference and deduction was presupposed; genetic analysis, by contrast, seeks to elucidate how *Erfahrung* is always a necessary condition for any such reductive account.¹³

Thus, with this 'new' understanding, we start to grasp a sedimented history in sense-bestowal and its various modalities.¹⁴ We can now trace 'a fundamental stratification' (*APAS*, s. 15, 105/64); we can now appreciate

the way in which an object-sense, the particular *cogitatum* of the *cogitationes* in question, becomes fashioned into a new sense in the changing flow of these *cogitationes* . . . [We] see how what is already at hand has been previously fashioned out of a foundation sense, which originated from an earlier performance.

(*FTL*, s. 97, 252/245)

Which is not to suggest that Husserl is 'merely' outlining the procession from the judgement 'S is P', to 'SP' (the categorial inclusion of P 'within' S), to the fresh predication 'SP is Q', to 'SPQ', to 'SPQ is R', and so on. . . .¹⁵ Certainly, intentionality itself is now revealed as layered and 'historical', containing deposit (*Niederschlag*) upon deposit; furthermore, association and anticipation are now recognized for their central roles in the

developmental, teleological structure of intentionality. (Association, the ‘universal principle [*universale Prinzip*] of passive genesis’ (CM, s. 39, 80/113), reveals how, despite changes in context and givenness, sensation is ‘organized’ according to previous encounter, how genesis is a development and not a mere series (*Nacheinander*); sense-data are now viewed in terms of an operative (*fungierende*) proto-intentionality, and thus as ‘anticipated constitution’. Accordingly, the earlier (psychologistic) dualism of sensation and intention is overcome, as the hyletic is revealed as being included ‘within’ the noetic.¹⁶) What is of more direct concern for us here is not so much the ‘solid structure’ revealed by this forward momentum within intentionality; it is more the ‘hinterland’, the before rather than the after, implied by the *Rückgang* and *Rückfrage* which are needed to understand this momentum. For what Husserl’s geneticism gestures towards is – as well as the changing flow of *cogitationes* grasped *qua* eidetic structure – that ‘untamed’ *Kernstoff*, itself allowing for pre-syntactical *Kernform* and *Kerngebilde*, which such understanding presupposes yet never contains.

That is to say, deduction can now be seen to refer back to a deeper-lying, concrete origination: this is unveiled in that reflective retrogression which attempts to re-execute the very event of judgement, and which suggests the *pre*-predicative presupposition of predication itself. Such a ‘return to origins’, taking us from categorial formations to their ‘grounding’ substrates, ultimately alerts us to an affective domain beyond the supposedly omnipotent grasp of the constituting ego. Before there is any cognitive act, we now find, there is the intuitive ‘certainty of being’ (*Seinsgewissheit*); before there is any ‘presence’, there is *preliminary* presence (*Voranliegen*); before there is any active intentionality, there is passive reception.

[The] domain of what is *pregiven*, of a *passive* *pregivenness* [*einer passiven Vorgegebenheit*] . . . [is] always already there without any attention of a grasping regard, without any awakening of interest. All cognitive activity, all turning-toward a particular object in order to grasp it, presupposes this domain of *passive* *pregivenness*.

(EJ, s. 7, 30; EU, 24)

Our knowledge depends upon the world’s prior ‘givenness of itself’: predicative judgements are impossible without such primal donation (*Gegebenheit*). The world, with its ‘fields’ and ‘horizons’, is always *already there* for us, pre-given in passive certitude, affecting us before we affect it.¹⁷

And, of course, the further we proceed with this *Rückgang*, the further we depart from an ‘all-conquering’ autarchy. Our *Abbau-Analyse*, our dismantling or ‘deconstruction’ of idealizations, assumptions, encrustations, and preconceptions, takes us to a point where the reflective subject is simply no longer present to itself: what we have, instead, is a kind of

affective, experiential ‘bedrock’ only manifest, implicitly, in certain traces or indications which it leaves behind. ‘Birdsong’, ‘the colour blue’, ‘the breeze on one’s face’, ‘the taste of sugar’ – these thematized significations indicate a ‘primitive’ ur-giveness which allows for and yet is more than thematization or signification. It is ‘more than’ in that it ‘does not lie open to the view of reflection but is only *implied* [*impliziert*] in the sedimentations [*Niederschlägen*] which refer to it’ (*EJ*, s. 11, 48; *EU*, 47); it is a hidden layer – ‘hidden because it is not capable of being exhibited as present [*aktuell*] in reflection in its intentional activity but can *only be indicated* by the sedimentations left’ (*ibid.*). Thus our active cognition, in trying to grasp its own origins, unfolds itself *qua* active cognition and is confronted by its passive, affective precondition – a precondition which is ‘unsayable’ in itself. Intentionality’s self-examination touches a *plus ultra*, an empty indication which cannot be filled and which is not simply a premonition or anticipation of what is yet to come; rather, it is the most extreme case of that ‘implicitly meant’ with which all of phenomenology is concerned. We could say that the ‘fullest’ understanding of constitution breaks through – irrupts – to reveal the ultimate dependency of understanding and constitution, the dependency upon sheer givenness. *Gegebenheit* is truly the ‘magic word’ (*Zauberwort*) of phenomenology.¹⁸

II Givenness and Intuition

Such is the position revealed by a very particular reading of Husserl’s genetic reconfiguration of phenomenology: autarchic subjectivity is, we see, unfolded on itself, relocated as the recipient of an antecedent givenness. And in this respect, we could say, genetic analysis confirms the ‘principle of principles’ (*Prinzip aller Prinzipien*) which was laid bare in *Id.* 1, before geneticism played any specific role in Husserl’s thought. For what that principle states, apparently unambiguously, is that any *logos* of phenomena must be formulated according to the primacy of phenomenality: it tells us that ‘every originary presentive intuition [*originär gebende Anschauung*] is a legitimizing source of cognition [*eine Rechtsquelle der Erkenntnis*], that everything organically . . . offered to us in “intuition” is to be accepted simply as what is presented as being . . .’ (*Id.* 1, s. 24; 44/*Hua*, 52–3).¹⁹ Thus, providing we accept this law, phenomenality is ‘delivered’ from external encumbrance: it is no longer answerable to formal conditions,²⁰ or to sufficient reason,²¹ but is entirely its own legitimation. The phenomenon, that is to say, can now appear *qua* phenomenon, as the appearance of itself and nothing but itself. Geneticism, it seems, is the logical outcome of phenomenology’s original ‘breakthrough’ to pure intuition.

To spell this out in more detail: the ‘principle of principles’ would have it that intuition *gives* us the world, whereas intention can only gesture towards it: without the ‘percept’, intended meanings remain empty,

unfulfilled, a ‘mere pointing’; meaning-intention requires meaning-fulfilment. The implications of this are that, with intuition accorded something like its full dignity, the way is open for a challenge to the supposed primacy of ‘reasons’, ‘meanings’, and ‘significations’, the *Ancien Régime* which had previously governed appearance. No longer must intuition submit itself to the refractory analytic of pure understanding; on the contrary, intuition is now revealed as ‘the ultimate legitimizing source of all rational assertions [*die letzte Rechtsquelle aller vernünftigen*]’ (*Id.* 1, s. 19, 36/36).²²

Needless to say, however, the overall situation is rather more complex – and problematic – than this partial history might suggest. A closer and more critical analysis not only locates a deep ambiguity within the ‘principle of principles’; it can also trace the continued and intensified presence of this same ambiguity in subsequent genetic developments.

The problem with the ‘principle of principles’ comes, as Jean-Luc Marion has established,²³ in Husserl’s failure to allow it fully to penetrate the operative supremacy of intentionality – and with this failure the possibility of ‘pure’ intuition is consistently curtailed by the horizon of predication. For while intuition appears to achieve primacy, this is no sooner established than it is undone: the self-giving of phenomena is still conditional upon a conceptual rule – truth as *adaequatio rei et intellectus* – and so intention is ‘reinscribed’ as a necessary condition for phenomenality’s appearance. The scales shift back to a conventional, metaphysical, position. As Marion puts it: ‘The phenomenon is possible in the strict measure that it agrees with the formal conditions of experience, thus with the power of knowing that fixes its attention on them, and therefore finally with the transcendental “I” itself’;²⁴ ‘intuition admits “limits” [*Schranken*] ... is characterized by scarcity, obeys a logic of shortage, and is stigmatized by an indelible [*ineffaceable*] insufficiency’.²⁵

The problem with Husserl’s subsequent genetic developments is a kind of repetition of that same, fateful reflex whereby the ‘metaphysics of presence’ prevails in the face of what should be its greatest challenge. Thus, according to a kind of revisionary *Aufhebung*, the ‘untamed’ affectivity which geneticism has touched upon is, if not civilized, then at least demarcated and ‘turned to the benefit’ of transcendental subjectivity. The passive hinterland which would seem at least potentially to undermine egological self-satisfaction is no sooner unveiled than it is ‘lifted up’ into a higher realm, ‘converted’ into a confirmation and guarantee of the sovereign power of transcendental subjectivity. Just as the ‘principle of principles’ is undone by the assumed supremacy of intentionality, so genetic phenomenology is redirected, away from its most radical implications.

If we might borrow and reconfigure (and reverse in order) two formulations of J. Derrida’s, the nature of this Husserlian *Aufhebung* may become clearer.

(1) The ‘untamed’ which the analysis of passive genesis touches upon ‘does not only concern phenomena that are experienced and self-evident’;²⁶ it therefore becomes extremely problematic phenomenologically to affirm these phenomena – phenomena which take us, ‘in confusion and in the dark’, closer and closer to ‘animality and nature in general’ – when such an affirmation, ‘made necessary *by* and *in* phenomenology itself, [cannot] be totally certain within phenomenology’.²⁷ The ur-given which genetic analysis goes towards is, as we know, irreducible.

(2) Nevertheless, the transition from static to genetic analysis can be regarded – despite the force of the ‘rupture’ just noted – as ‘a simple progress which implies no “surpassing” [*dépassement*] (as it is called) and still less an option, and especially not a repentance [*repentir*].’²⁸ Rather, what we have here is ‘a work of excavation in which the baring of both the genetic foundations and the original productivity not only neither shakes nor ruins the superficial structures already unearthed, but also brings eidetic forms once again to light, that is the “structural a prioris” – this is Husserl’s expression – of genesis itself’.²⁹

As we shall see, it is precisely the apparent ease with which (1) gives way to (2) – that is, the ease with which such a radical rupture can be smoothed over and, ultimately, used to confirm the domain of structural analysis (as well as the egological impulse which this slide reveals) – that is of such significance. For what is laid bare here, in this *Aufhebung*, is nothing less than the fate of a non-ontological phenomenology of givenness. To make this explicit – that is, to make explicit the egology which frames and subsumes the ur-given – we need to return to those works which announced ‘fully formed’ genetic phenomenology, reading them this time with an eye to their wider schema, their overall dimensions.

III Givenness as Confirmation of Transcendental Egology

The *FTL* and *EJ* both seek, as we know, to search ‘beneath’ formal analysis: they move back from ideal constructions to the *Erfahrung* these constitutions must presuppose. The predicative is located in terms of pre-predicative origination; and any currently constituted intentional unity is revealed to have a rich and complex sedimented history. We are taken, it seems, to the very threshold of subjectivity, to the *world* which sustains the self. Nonetheless, and whatever the implications of this breakthrough, Husserl’s overall concern turns resolutely towards the ‘solid structure’ for which passive reception allows, the after rather than the before: his explicit aim is that eidetic structure take precedence over supposed irreducibility. What is ‘truly significant’ about genetic analysis is that

we understand ourselves in this revelation of intentional implications, in the interrogation of the origin of the sedimentation of sense

[*Sinnesniederschläge*] from intentional operations, as *transcendental subjectivity*, where, by ‘transcendental’, nothing more is to be understood than the theme, originally inaugurated by Descartes, of a regressive inquiry concerning the ultimate source of all cognitive formations, of a reflection by the knowing subject on himself and on his cognitive life.

(*EJ*, s. 11, 49–50; *EU*, 48–9)

The identification and demarcation of facticity and immersion – *das-In-der-Welt-seiende-Ich* – can now be seen as proof of the power of subjectivity: after all, it is only the transcendental ego which can identify such worldliness (*FTL*, s. 99, 223/*Hua* 252). In turn, *that* we are worlded becomes sublated by the *how* of this worldhood: *quoddity*, ‘sheer that-ness’, is treated as a mode of *quiddity*, as the ‘result’ of my synthetic consciousness; being and being-thus are only what is ‘*accepted by me* [*mir geltend*]’ (*FTL*, s. 94, 234/241). So, while it remains ‘obvious that . . . I can be conditioned by something “external”, by something that goes beyond my self-contained ownness’, nevertheless, such conclusions are always ‘the results of systematic sense-investigations concerning the world, which, as a “phenomenon”, lies within me myself and gets its being-sense from me [*aus mir ihren Seinssinn hat*]’ (*FTL*, s. 104, 276/282). Similarly, whatever is given may be ‘more than what is actually itself grasped’, and the world as a whole ‘utterly transcendent of me, of my own being’ (*FTL*, s. 94, 233/240); but this surplus is only ‘there’ for me *via my own experience*: ‘nothing exists for me otherwise than by virtue of the *actual and potential performance of my own consciousness* [*für mich nichts ist, es sei denn aus eigener aktueller oder potenzieller Bewußtseinsleistung*]’ (s. 94, 234/207); [t]he world’s transcendence is a transcendence relative to this Ego [*Die Transzendenz der Welt ist Transzendenz in Relation zu diesem Ich*]’ (s. 99, 251/258). Thus the significance of identifying our passive ‘grounding’ is more the identification itself rather than that which is identified; attention is firmly focused upon our capacity for structural, eidetic demarcation. ‘Whatever I encounter as an existing object is something that . . . has received its *whole* being-sense [*ganzen Seinssinn*] for me from my effective intentionality; not a shadow of that sense remains excluded from my effective [*leistenden*] intentionality’ (s. 94, 234/241): such a formula would now seem to hold sway even when the encountered ‘object’ is that penumbral layer of ur-giveness itself hidden to intentional activity. The ego’s identification of its ‘hinterland’, far from unsettling self-certainty, now seems only to bolster egology. Genetic phenomenology is ‘the ultimate science’ (*APAS*, s. 1, 5/*Hua* XVII, 354), ‘an absolute method’ (*ibid.*, 7/355), ‘science in the highest sense’ (*ibid.*, 7/356).

In and through all of this – and this can hardly come as any surprise – the autarchic monad is left rampant in its certitude; sublating the ur-given can

only intensify its self-prescribed prestige. ‘First of all, before everything else conceivable, *I am*’ (*FTL*, s. 95, 237/243); ‘I, the “transcendental ego”, am the ego who “precedes” everything worldly’ (s. 96, 238/245); ‘With an insuperable necessity [*unübersteiglicher Notwendigkeit*], the ego is primary (s. 95, 236–7/243); Being is ‘legitimated’ [*ausweisend*] in my intentionality (s. 96, 237/244). From now on, Husserl contends, all sciences, all formal ontologies, can be seen for what they are – as ‘*branches of a constituted production from the one transcendental subjectivity*’ (s. 103, 272/279). Egology reaches a paroxysmal high-point:

The whole of phenomenology is nothing more than scientific self-examination [wissenschaftliche Selbstbesinning] on the part of transcendental subjectivity.

(s. 104, 273/280)

[E]very existent is ultimately relative; not only everything that is relative in any usual sense, but every existent is relative to transcendental subjectivity. Transcendental subjectivity alone, on the other hand, exists ‘in itself and for itself’.

(s. 103, 273/279)

[T]he subjective Apriori precedes the being of God and world, the being of everything, individually and collectively, for me, the thinking subject. Even God is what he is, in consequence of my own productivity of consciousness [aus meiner eigenen Bewußtseinsleistung].

(s. 99, 251/258)

We can be left in little doubt, then, that the overall tendency of genetic analysis is towards confirming the domain of the transcendental ego; whatever the *Rückgang* may have unearthed, the ‘solid developmental structure’ of transcendental consciousness is what really matters. Provided that the constitution of the laws of genesis is prized over the primitive non-presence to which these laws silently refer, the ur-given can always be swept under the carpet, its potential subversion kept out of sight.

IV Givenness and ‘Husserlian Ontology’

Perhaps, though, we miss an important point if we think that Husserl has reserved a sort of rough treatment for the particular case of the untamed ur-given. No doubt this is a very particular case: after all, and as we have seen, phenomenology is here faced with a ‘phenomenon’ which escapes self-evident experience; as such, this ‘phenomenon’ would seem to offer the deepest challenge to any phenomenological affirmation. But to understand

how and why this challenge is effaced, we need to put Husserl's treatment of this 'pure givenness' within the wider context of his overall approach to 'the ontological' in general.

To put it bluntly: what we could term Husserlian ontology is rarely more than a means to some transcendental–egological end. Despite the radical breakthrough of categorial intuition, the formal ontology of the *LI* is primarily concerned with acts of judgement regarding objectivity; although formal-apophantic logic is widened, this is only a stage in the movement from analytic to transcendental logic. (Overall, epistemology – philosophy's 'cardinal question' (*Kardinalfrage*) (s. 3, 56/*Hua* 23) – is anterior to ontology (s. 61, 221/*Hua* 225–6).) As well as stating the 'principle of principles', *Id.* 1 may make certain suggestions regarding the 'existential' presuppositions of consciousness (s. 39); it may also show how immanent perception is open to objects' self-disclosure, to their 'admission of being known' (s. 43). But its fundamental contention remains, of course, that thinghood depends upon subjectivity *qua* constitution: the world is contingent, Husserl tells us, whereas the pure Ego is necessary (s. 46). (Transcendental consciousness is 'the primal category of all being . . . in which all other regions of being are rooted, to which, according to their *essence*, they are relative and on which they are therefore all essentially dependent', s. 76, 171/174.) *Id.* 2, despite outlining the areas of *Natur*, *Leib*, *Seele*, and *Geist*, still treats such 'regional ontologies' as reducible to various positional modalities: they are, first and foremost, theoretic possibilities for consciousness. *Id.* 3 goes further, telling us that regional ontologies 'fall under the blow of the reduction' (s. 13, 65/76) and that any 'science of onta' 'dissolves into the phenomenological' (s. 14, 66–7/78). Even the *Hua* VIII texts, *Idee der vollen Ontologie* (1924) and *Phänomenologie als absolute und universale Ontologie* (1923), are concerned with the *forms* of the world, rather than its *quoddity*; such a 'science of possible forms' (*die Wissenschaft von den möglichen Formen*), Husserl tells us, is transcendental phenomenology (*Idee der vollen Ontologie*, *Hua* VIII, 213). (*Erste Philosophie* seems to underline this tendency, stating that ontology's 'significant function' (*bedeutsame Funktion*) is to provide guiding leads for a universal phenomenology (Drittes Kapital, I, s. 26, *Hua* VII, 187).) Thus, by the time of the *CM*, we get confirmation of what we already know well: that, for Husserl, 'material and formal ontological regions . . . [are] indexes pointing to transcendental systems of evidence' (*CM*, s. 29, 62/97), and that Husserlian phenomenology is, *eo ipso*, transcendental idealism (s. 41, 86/118).³⁰ Overall, Husserl's concern is with the formal constitution of 'regional' experience, not with empirical reference or a priori ontology as such. Ultimately, 'the question is not how things in general *are*, nor what in truth belongs to them as such, but how the consciousness of things is made' (*Id.* 3, s. 15, 72/84).³¹

It is within this fundamentally idealistic context, then, that we should judge the particular treatment meted out to the untamed ur-given. For, in a sense, there is nothing new in Husserl's response here: it was ever thus that, for Husserl, any ontological 'stuff' be treated as a mere reference to the constituting ego. And this, perhaps, is the solution to the apparent riddle that – even with the constituting subject questioned, unfolded, and undone to the extent which passive ur-givenness might suggest – transcendental egology continues unaffected in its self-certainty. For *the attitude towards 'Being in general' has already determined how givenness will be treated*: namely, as egological ballast, as an index to transcendental subjectivity's self-understanding. This is why the fundamental challenge of the non-present, non-evident, 'untamed' ur-given is never fully confronted; and this is how Husserl can opt for a Procrustean structural enforcement which treats ur-given phenomenality no differently from any 'accountable' phenomenon. In short, locating pure givenness while denying Being means locating pure givenness in terms of the subject.

So it is that the genetic analyses, despite their implications, end up confirming what Husserl had already made plain in *Id. 1*: that givenness, no matter how radical, should always be seen in terms of my 'inner' experience. Givenness, that is, serves only to confirm 'my pure Ego and its personal life, which is "necessary"'; beyond this there is only '*presumptive reality*' (*presumptive Wirklichkeit*), *contingent* (*zufällige*) Being (*Id. 1*, s. 46, 102/108).³²

V Conclusion

Husserl's breakthrough to that sheer givenness which forms the pre-supposition of experience remains one of phenomenology's greatest achievements: thematization and signification are here 'put in their place', as dependent upon a gratuitous plenitude which is always more than their product or outcome; accordingly, constitution and egological regime are dethroned, their privileges withdrawn. However, treating this givenness as givenness without Being is, as we have seen, fraught with difficulty: givenness outside the matrix of the 'is' can only manifest itself, in all its splendour, *through the 'I'*; in other words, givenness is still modulated, in classically egological terms, as confirming the 'necessary' self. Thus a very egological economy prevails: whatever its deconstructive power, geneticism ends up sanctifying autarchy.

Gegebenheit may well be the magic word of phenomenology; but it can also present a great stumbling block (*Stein des Anstoßes*).³³

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Abbreviations

APAS: Analyses Concerning Passive and Active Synthesis, trans. Anthony J. Steinbock, Dordrecht: Kluwer, 2001; *Hua XVII, Formale und transzendente Logik. Versuch einer Kritik der logischen Vernunft. Mit ergänzenden Texten*, Hrsg. Paul Jannssen, Dordrecht: Kluwer, 1974; *Hua XI: Analysen zur passiven Synthesis. Aus Vorlesungs- und Forschungsmanskripten (1918–1926)*, Hrsg. M. Fleischer, Dordrecht: Kluwer, 1988; *Hua XIV: Zur Phänomenologie der Intersubjektivität. Texte aus dem Nachlaß. Zweiter Teil. 1921–1928*, Hrsg. I. Kern, Dordrecht: Kluwer, 1973.

CM: Cartesian Meditations: An Introduction to Phenomenology, trans. D. Cairns, The Hague: Nijhoff, 1960; *Cartesianische Meditationen und Pariser Vorträge*, *Husserliana* I, Hrsg. Stephan Strasser, Dordrecht: Kluwer, 1991.

EJ/EU: Experience and Judgement: Investigations in a Genealogy of Logic, ed. L. Landgrebe, trans. J. S. Churchill and K. Ameriks, Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 1973; *Erfahrung und Urteil. Untersuchungen zur Genealogie der Logik*, Hrsg. Ludwig Landgrebe, Hamburg: Felix Meiner Verlag, 1972.

FTL: Formal and Transcendental Logic, trans. Dorion Cairns, The Hague: Nijhoff, 1969; *Hua XVII, Formale und transzendente Logik. Versuch einer Kritik der logischen Vernunft. Mit ergänzenden Texten*, Hrsg. Paul Jannssen, Dordrecht: Kluwer, 1974.

Hua VII: Erste Philosophie (1923/24), Erster Teil: Kritische Ideengeschichte, Hrsg. R. Boehm, Dordrecht: Kluwer, 1965.

Hua XV: Zur Phänomenologie der Intersubjektivität. Texte aus dem Nachlaß. Dritter Teil. 1929–1935, Hrsg. I. Kern, Dordrecht: Kluwer, 1973.

Hua XXIV: Einleitung in die Logik und Erkenntnistheorie. Vorlesungen 1906/07, Hrsg. Ullrich Melle. Dordrecht: Kluwer, 1985.

Id. 1: Ideas Pertaining to a Pure Phenomenology and to a Phenomenological Philosophy, First Book, trans. Fred Kersten, Dordrecht: Kluwer, 1983 (also: *Ideas. A General Introduction to Pure Phenomenology*, trans. W. R. Boyce Gibson, London: Allen & Unwin, 1931); *Hua III/1, Ideen zu einer reinen Phänomenologie und phänomenologischen Philosophie. Erstes Buch: Allgemeine Einführung in die reine Phänomenologie, I. Halbband: Text der 1–3. Auflage*, Hrsg. K. Schuhmann, Dordrecht: Kluwer, 1977.

Id. 2: Ideas Pertaining to a Pure Phenomenology and to a Phenomenological Philosophy, Second Book, trans. R. Rojewicz and A. Schuwer, Dordrecht: Kluwer, 1989; *Hua IV, Ideen zu einer reinen Phänomenologie und phänomenologischen Philosophie. Zweites Buch: Phänomenologische Untersuchungen zur Konstitution*, Hrsg. Marly Biemel, Dordrecht: Kluwer, 1991.

Id. 3: Ideas Pertaining to a Pure Phenomenology and to a Phenomenological Philosophy. Book 3: Phenomenology and the Foundations of the Sciences, trans. Ted E. Klein and William E. Pohl, The Hague: Nijhoff, 1980; *Hua V: Ideen zu einer reinen Phänomenologie und phänomenologischen Philosophie, Drittes Buch, Die Phänomenologie und die Fundamente der Wissenschaften*, Hrsg. Marly Biemel, Dordrecht: Kluwer, 1971.

LI: Logical Investigations, trans. J. N. Findlay, 2 vols, New York: Humanities Press, 1970; *Hua XVIII, Logische Untersuchungen. Erster Band: Prolegomena zur reinen Logik, Text der 1. und 2. Auflage*, Hrsg. E. Holenstein, Dordrecht: Kluwer, 1975; *Hua XIX, Logische Untersuchungen, Zweiter Band: Untersuchungen zur Phänomenologie und Theorie der Erkenntnis*, Hrsg. Ursula Panzer, Dordrecht: Kluwer, 1984.

Notes

- 1 See, for example, *FTL*, Conclusion/*Schlusswort*, 290–1/*Hua* 297.
- 2 Cf. *CM*, s. 37, 77/*Hua* 110.
- 3 Cf. *Id.* 1, s. 85.
- 4 Boyce Gibson translation (London: Allen & Unwin, 1931), p. 260. Kersten, whose translation I use on all other occasions, has: 'We receive the answer in the pure directedness to *something given* in its essence' (p. 216). See *Hua* III, 221: 'Wir erhalten die Antwort in reiner Hingabe an das wesensmäßig Gegebene, wir können das "Erscheinende als solches" getreu, in vollkommener Evidenz beschreiben.'
- 5 See, esp., *Id.* 1, s. 89, where the implicit threat lurking throughout *Id.* 1 as a whole is made explicit and sensuous *hyle* becomes well and truly idealized.
- 6 See, for example, the *Selbstanzeige* for *LI*, vol. 2, *Hua* XIX, 2, 779; and *Id.* 1, s. 1, trans. p. 5, n. 2, *Hua* III/1, 10, n. 1.
- 7 We should notice, however, at *Id.* 1, s. 81, a certain anticipation of genetic developments. See also *APAS*, 644/*Hua* XIV, 41, where Husserl credits his earlier, static analysis with providing a 'leading clue' (*Leitfaden*) which allows the opening into genetic understanding. Cf. *Hua* XV, 616.
- 8 Cf. *Id.* 3, *Hua* V, 125–6.
- 9 We might also note, in this respect, Husserl's prefiguration of the Heideggerian *Zuhandenheit/Vorhandenheit* distinction: where the 'naturalistic' attitude is theoretical, the 'personalistic' is involved, immersed, inseparably related to its surrounding world; this everyday worldhood is always prior to any theoretical detachment. See, esp., *Id.* 2, ss. 49e, 50, 53.
- 10 As Husserl himself will observe of static phenomenology (*CM*, s. 37, p. 110, trans. pp. 76–7): 'its descriptions are analogous to those of natural history, which concern particular types and, at best, arrange them in their systematic order. Questions of universal genesis and the genetic structure of the ego in his universality, so far as that structure is more than temporal, are still far away; and, indeed, they belong to a higher level.' See also *APAS*, 642–4/*Hua* XIV, 40–1, and *APAS*, 628–9/*Hua* XI, 340, and 634/345.
- 11 Cairns uses 'historicalness' for *Historizität*.
- 12 See, for example, *APAS*, s. 9, 31/*Hua* XVII, 373.
- 13 See also *APAS*, s. 5, 18–19/*Hua* XI, 364: 'in contrast to [the *ego cogito*] we have a broad lived-experiential field, or as we can also say, a field of consciousness

- that has not entered into such a relation with the ego or with which the ego has not entered into such a relation'. See also 19/364: 'the *ego cogito* thus has a constant, broad horizon of background lived-experiences to which the ego is not present and "in" which it does not reside'.
- 14 See Dorion Cairns, *Conversations with Husserl and Fink*, *Phaenomenologica* 66 (The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff, 1975), p. 20 (Aug. 1931), and p. 65 (Jan. 1932).
 - 15 See *FTL*, Appendix II, s. 1, trans. 313–14/*Hua* 314–15.
 - 16 See the later note added to *Id.* 1, *Hua* 478: 'Zur Noesis gehören also die hyletischen Momente.' See also G. Brand, *Welt, Ich und Zeit: nach unveröffentlichten Manuskripten Edmund Husserls* (The Hague: Nijhoff, 1955), p. 27.
 - 17 See Karl Schuhmann, *Husserl-Chronik. Denk- und Lebensweg Edmund Husserls*, *Husserliana Dokumente*, vol. 1 (The Hague: Nijhoff, 1977).
 - 18 See Heidegger, *Grundprobleme der Phänomenologie* (1919/20), Hrsg. Hans-Helmuth Gander, Gesamtausgabe 58 (Frankfurt am Main: Vittorio Klosterman, 1993), p. 5.
 - 19 Cf. Boyce Gibson's translation, p. 92: 'every primordial *dator intuition* is a source of authority (*Rechtsquelle*) for knowledge . . . whatever presents itself in "intuition" in primordial form . . . is simply to be accepted as it gives itself out to be'. See also the supplementary preface to the *LU*, second edition, published posthumously as 'Entwurf einer Vorrede zu den *Logischen Untersuchungen*' (1913), ed. Eugen Fink, *Tijdschrift voor Philosophie*, 1 (1939), pp. 116–17.
 - 20 See Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*, A218/B265, A219/B266, A220/B267.
 - 21 See Leibniz, *New Essays on Human Understanding*, IV, II, s. 8.
 - 22 Levinas understood this well: 'To say that intuition actualizes the mere intention which aims at the object is to say that in intuition we relate directly to the object, we reach it. That is the entire difference between aiming at something and reaching it. . . . A signifying intention only thinks about an object, but intuition gives us something of the object itself.' See *The Theory of Intuition in Husserl's Phenomenology*, 2nd edn, trans. André Orianne (Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 1995), p. 67; *Théorie de l'Intuition dans la phénoménologie de Husserl* (Paris: Vrin, 1970), pp. 103–4.
 - 23 See, especially, 'The Saturated Phenomenon', trans. Thos Carlson, *Philosophy Today*, 40 (1996), pp. 103–124/'Le Phénomène saturé', in *Phénoménologie et théologie*, ed. Jean-François Courtine (Paris: Criterion, 1992), pp. 79–128. Hereafter SP/PS.
 - 24 SP, 118/PS, 119.
 - 25 SP, 105/PS, 85–6.
 - 26 Jacques Derrida, "'Genesis and Structure" and Phenomenology', in *Writing and Difference*, trans. Alan Bass (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1978), pp. 154–68, p. 165; "'Genèse et structure et la phénoménologie de Husserl', in *L'Écriture et la différence* (Paris: Editions du Seuil, 1967), pp. 229–51, p. 248. The French original refers to 'des phénomènes et des evidences vécues'.
 - 27 *Ibid.*
 - 28 *Ibid.*, trans. p. 156; original, p. 231.
 - 29 *Ibid.*
 - 30 The *CM* therefore 'consummates' what was already outlined at *Id.* 3, s. 12, 70–5: that phenomenology *qua* universal science 'swallows up' all ontologies. This is the matrix within which we should locate the claim that phenomenology represents, *ipso facto*, 'the true and genuine universal ontology' (*CM* s. 64, 155/*Hua* 181).

- 31 In 1906/7, Husserl goes so far as to state that phenomenology is ‘nowise an ontology [*überhaupt keine Ontologie*]’. See *Apriorische Ontologie und Phänomenologie*, in *Hua XXIV, Beilage IV*, 422.
- 32 Cf. Rudolf Boehm, ‘Zum Begriff des “Absoluten” bei Husserl’, *Zeitschrift für philosophie Forschung*, 13 (1959), pp. 214–42, esp. p. 237.
- 33 See Heidegger, *Grundprobleme der Phänomenologie*, p. 5: ‘Was heißt “gegeben”, “Gegebenheit” – dieses Zauberwort der Phänomenologie und der “Stein des Anstoßes” bei den anderen.’